

**To What Extent are National Education Policies Aligning with
Global Sustainable Development Goal 4?**

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Abstract

With NEP's launch in 2020, began a new dawn of Indian education. It had multiple propositions about adding to, modifying and even deleting some long existing policies related to development of a good education system in India. It was formulated against the backdrop of SDG 4. This paper would try to trace the origin of SDG, NEP and through it, would uncover the underlying relationship between the two in order to trace the similarities and differences that exist. The paper would conclude with some achievements of NEP thus far and with it, certain challenges that have appeared during the research. In essence, both NEP and SDG 4 are unified in their aim of achieving 100% literacy and GER with quality education, vocational courses and teachers' training to create an environment of learning where it is not tedious or overbearing to get educated, but instead, offers a liberating experience.

Keywords: Education, Learning, NEP, SDG, United Nations, Goals, India, Context and Introduction

Education serves as the backbone of any and every society. No matter where one is in the world, it is the key to a better life, for both individuals and communities. A good education can open doors to better jobs, reducing poverty, improving health, and helping people participate more in society. Even though its importance is universal, access to quality education remains unequal. In many places, students and those who want to gain access to an education face serious hurdles to learning. Whether it be because of poverty, discrimination, or the lack of resources, these challenges all led to the creation of the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals. This total of seventeen goals are all aiming to address some of the biggest issues the world is facing by 2030. Among them, Sustainable Development Goal 4 stands out as the cornerstone of education. Sustainable Development Goal 4 (SDG 4) mainly aims to 'ensure inclusive and

equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all.’ When it was adopted in 2015, this goal worked to encourage countries across the globe to not only make it so all had a basic access to schooling, but to also improve the quality of the education itself. The idea that learning should not be limited to just learning to learn but rather to empower students, all students, to change the world was a driving force for this goal. SDG 4 highlights how education connects to other global priorities as well. This includes, but is not limited to, public health, gender equality, economic development, and environmental sustainability. While it is an extremely complex vision, it is imperative that people recognize just how important its outcomes can be. Even though SDG 4 was part of a global project, national governments need to be held accountable for running the education systems within their countries. From building the schools and training the teachers to deciding what students learn and how learning is measured, the national government is needed. Because SDG 4 involved a shared set of goals among the world, it can often be difficult to map this as each and every country as its own political, economic and social structures, so what works in one country may not work in another. Because of this, there can be gaps in global goals. How each government chooses to fund these projects, implement certain policies, and provide teacher support, can affect the overall progress made toward SDG 4. Some countries have made it clear that achieving this goal is a priority by investing heavily in education and helping it reach populations that would otherwise not have been able to get an education. Other nations have struggled for a plethora of reasons, especially things regarding limited resources and political turmoil. The COVID-19 pandemic highlighted these gaps even more. When schools around the entire world closed down, it led to significant losses in learning for disadvantaged students the most. In countries that had strong government leadership and better access to county education for their students, they were able to adjust to the curveball.

However, others fell behind. Those located in some regions of Latin America, Africa, and Asia bore the most significant loss. This created what some are calling the ‘earning crisis.’ This topic is extremely important to understand because its ambitious goals can lead to beyond positive impacts for the world. Education plays such an important role in shaping everything, but because access to quality education is so far from equal, and so much depends on geographic luck and the structure of each and every national government, being able to fully understand SDG 4 helps provide an opportunity to further explore how things work. Being genuinely interested in education helped drive my interest in the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals. As a student in highschool, I have seen just how much education truly does shape opportunities in every day possible. I also know that not everyone gets the same experience, but reaching SDG 4 would help support growth for all. This topic also speaks on themes that I largely believe in. Fueling growth in areas of fairness and equity raise concerns beyond education. This topic is rooted in the understanding that education is not just a policy issue, but a matter of justice. Social change and activism are also fundamental principles that I believe in, and education offers one of the most powerful platforms to make a real difference. Any movements regarding injustices in the world intersect with education. An empowered, educated, and diverse population is much more likely to demand accountability and advocate for fairer systems. Sustainable development can be defined as a strategy of development that meets the needs of the present generation without compromising the requirements of generations to come. Basically, a method of progress that tries to achieve development with optimal use of resources. Increasing population, tensions amongst countries and communities and depleting resources gave birth to dire state of events and realizing the need for intervention, all the member countries of the United Nations came together and agreed on the ‘2030 agenda for sustainable development’ in September 2015 which at its

core, dealt with 17 major sustainable development goals which encompassed 169 targets divided amongst the goals. According to the UN, the three major tenets of sustainable development are economic growth, social inclusion and environmental protection. Although these goals are not legally binding, countries are expected to monitor and implement these as they resonate with their own SDGs, development and political environment (UNO, 2025a). These goals were neither overnight thoughts nor the decision of any one country. They were a result of continuous efforts, multiple conferences and long drawn processes to ensure that all of mankind benefits from them. It is hence very important to understand the road to these developments and find where these goals originated from. The following paragraph discusses a brief history of these sustainable development goals and how they were transformed from ideas to reality.

On 2nd-3rd December 1989, US president George Bush and the president of the then USSR Mikhail Gorbachev met near the coast of Malta for Malta summit, which many scholars understood as the end of the cold war that had spanned for nearly 4 decades (Nelsson, 2024). Bush famously remarked about the summit; “the stage has now been set for progress over a broad set of issues” (Pick, 1989). Following this new surge of ties and energy among the eastern and western bloc post the cold war in the 1990s, the United Nations engineered a series of conferences and meetings on crucial issues like child nutrition, gender inequality and many other facets of human rights to garner a much needed unified and collective global response. One such summit was the 1995 ‘World Summit on Social Development’ which gave birth to the ‘Copenhagen Declaration on Social Development’ (UNO, 1995), the document that had a long list of commitments from global leaders. However, due to the repeatedly falling international aid, the Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) set up a machinery to reflect on the development aid. The result of this was a 1996 report titled ‘Shaping the 21st

Century’ which used some content from the Copenhagen development summit report and turned them into ‘International Development Goals’, the source for millennium development goals (launched in 2000) and eventual origin of the sustainable development goals (OECD, 1996). In 1997, the UN general assembly sought to form a ‘Millennium Assembly’ to reform its system (UNO, 1998). However a year later, a halt was put on this assembly. Instead, the then secretary general of the UN, Kofi Annan was mandated to present with developmental suggestions about "a number of forward-looking and widely relevant topics" (UNO, 1999). A year later, Annan published his report titled ‘We the Peoples: The Role of the United Nations in the 21st Century’. The report primarily focused on how the world needs to come together; about how globalization needs a zeal that would not just initiate development but will also not leave anyone lagging behind. Annan also urged the members of the then upcoming Millennium summit to adopt goals and objectives from previously held conferences and meetings like the Copenhagen Summit and multiple conferences throughout the 90s (Annan, 2000).

Following the road map set by Annan, The Millennium Summit under the aegis the General Assembly issued a Millennium Declaration in 2000 (UNO, 2000). Although the declaration did not have the terms ‘millennium development goals’ outrightly written in it, the concept was the same and so, its significance resided in the fact that finally, the OECD’s and the UN’s approach subsumed a striking chord. Ultimately, MDGs were developed, keeping in mind the singing of the millennium declaration. It had 8 goals and 21 targets. These 8 major goals were eradicating extreme poverty and hunger, achieving universal primary education, promoting gender equality and empowering women, reducing child mortality, improving maternal health, combating HIV/AIDS, malaria and other diseases, ensuring environmental sustainability and creating a global partnership for development by 2015 (UNO, 2025b).

Although MDGs were able to meet certain targets in 15 years, some even before the deadline, it was said that the development was uneven. To tackle this, the UN secretary general decided to form a UN task team to discuss the ‘Post 2015 Development Agenda’ (UNO, 2012). This ultimately gave birth to SDGs that are in action till 2030. SDGs take one step further from the MDGs because they plan to hit the root cause of issues, as discussed in the initial paragraphs of this research paper.

A Brief Introduction to NEP

The consultation process of forming a new education policy was initiated in October 2015 through a committee constituted under the aegis of Mr. T. S. R. Subramaniam, former bureaucrat and cabinet secretary of India from 1996 to 1998. The goal of this committee was to point out and address the lacunae that persisted in the education system of India. The committee submitted its report in 2016 (PRS, 2025). The policy, as said by the Indian government, was the first major development in the area of education since the education policy of 1986. Even though there was an upgrade to that policy in 1992, it is now said to be just a ‘rehash’ of the 1986 policy (Chaturvedi, 2020).

Based off the report that was published by T. S. R. Subramaniam committee, a primary draft of the new education policy was submitted in 2019 by a committee led by former ISRO chief, Dr. Krishnaswamy Kasturirangan (Barman, 2021). Following this, a Draft NEP (D-NEP) was released by the Ministry of Human Resource Development (MHRD) in 2019 (PTI, 2019). This draft NEP was a hefty document of 484 pages which was reduced to 66 pages in the final policy (Panagariya, 2020). It is to be duly noted that as per the government sources, rigorous consultation was done to form the policy. This included receiving over 2 lakh suggestions from 2.5 lakh gram panchayats, 6,600 blocks and 6,000 urban local bodies from over 650 districts of

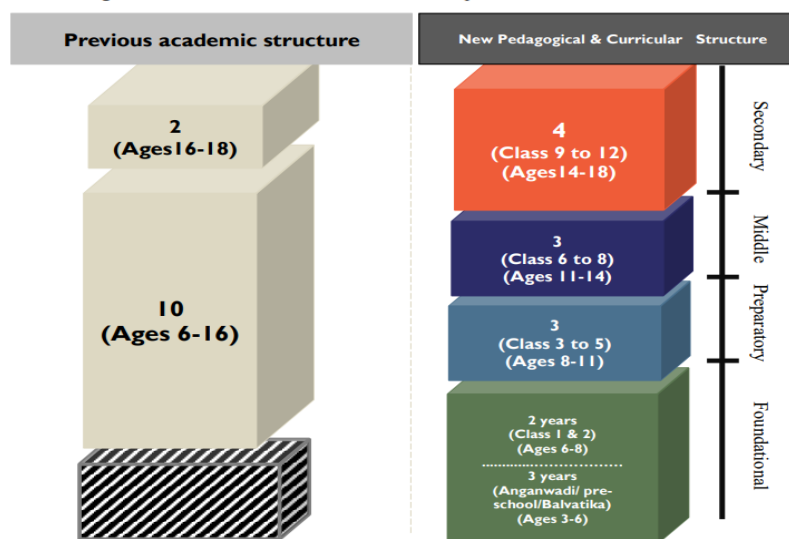
the country (Hebbar and Jebaraj, 2020). Finally, amidst all the speculations, criticism and appreciation, the new education policy (NEP 2020) was adopted on July 29th, 2020 to serve as “an ambitious roadmap” that would transform Indian schools into “spaces where learning is no longer confined to textbooks, marks, or memorization” (PIB, 2025). To add on, it is also significant to know that with the enactment of NEP 2020, the government of India also aimed at increasing the expenditure on education from being 3-4% then to around 6% of the GDP (Upadhyay, 2020).

To assess the practicality of the ideas behind NEP 2020, it is important to know how things stand at present. As of July 2025, the schools in India run on the NCF-SE (National Curriculum Framework for School Education), 2023 which is designed to promote more experiential learning than theoretical knowledge and inculcate competency in young minds and hence, half of questions asked now in the CBSE board exams are competency-based. Additionally, the ‘NIPUN bharat’ and ‘Vidya pravesh’ schemes have reached 4.2 crore students across 8.9 lakh schools, more than 1.15 lakh students belonging to socio-economically weak backgrounds and 7.58 lakh girls took admissions in residential school, ‘PRASHAST’, a special screening app was launched for disabled students and ‘Indian sign language’ is now a subject with over 1000 books videos and audio books developed on it. Moreover, almost 3/4th of all the schools in the country now have internet and ‘e-Jaadui Pitara’ has now brought AI run multilingual learning to initial grades too. Finally, aligning with SDG 4’s teachers’ training targets, over 4 lakh teachers were trained under NISHTHA; Foundational Literacy and Numeracy (FLN) and Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) modules integrated through DIKSHA (PIB, 2025).

NEP and its relationship with SDG 4

This chapter will present an up-close analysis of the functioning relationship between SDG 4 and the New Education Policy adopted by India in 2020, five years after the UN's declaration to adopt Sustainable Development Goals. It is important to also note that NEP recently saw some minor reforms in 2024 which include schools now having a 5+3+3+4 structure instead of a 10+2 framework, introduction of technical knowledge like coding from grade 6, e-learning in regional languages too and not just hindi and english and a stronger emphasis on vocational training and making students more 'employable' (Agarwal, 2024).

Part I. SCHOOL EDUCATION
This policy envisages that the extant 10+2 structure in school education will be modified with a new pedagogical and curricular restructuring of 5+3+3+4 covering ages 3-18 as shown in the representative figure and elaborated in detail later under Chapter 4.



6

(MHRD, 2020, p.6)

India's new education policy aims at solving many significant issues that have crippled the education system in India, much like how SDG 4 has targets aimed at countering the unfair and uneven dissemination of education at a global level. It goes without saying that the new education policy had to be framed keeping SDG 4 as one of the inspirations. The following

paragraphs will deal with targets set by SDG 4 and NEP before arriving at junctures of similarities and differences between the two.

Major Targets set under SDG 4

This study deals specifically with Sustainable Development Goal number 4 or SDG 4 and analyzes as to what extent do Indian national education policies align with it. SDG 4 is titled ‘Ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all’ or in short, quality education and elucidates 10 targets under it. All of these targets are to be realized by 2030 and intend to work on all the major areas which are crucial in achieving compulsory and quality education for everyone. Some of these areas of significance are universal and free access to primary and secondary education, early childhood care and education, gender equality and societal inclusion for everyone including indigenous and disabled people, affordable access to technical and vocational skill development for enhanced employability, higher education access to everyone willing, teachers’ training and adult education and ultimately promoting humanity, non-violent ideas, global citizenship, cultural diversity and peaceful co-existence (SDG resource document, 2020, p.4).

Given below is a self-created table that summarizes the targets under SDG 4.

Target Number	What It Sets to Achieve
4.1	Free, quality primary & secondary education for all by 2030.
4.2	Access to quality early childhood education by 2030.
4.3	Equal access to affordable tertiary & vocational education.
4.4	Boost youth/adult skills for jobs, work, entrepreneurship.
4.5	End gender & social gaps in all levels of education.
4.6	Achieve youth literacy & numeracy; improve adult skills.
4.7	Teach sustainability, peace, rights, global citizenship.
4.a	Build safe, inclusive, gender- & disability-friendly schools.
4.b	More scholarships for developing countries (esp. STEM).
4.c	More trained teachers via international cooperation.

Major Targets set under NEP

NEP can be seen as an ambitious event in the history of Indian education which has attempted (and to some extent, achieved) the revolutionization of the Indian education system. Part of it is because of the targets it has set. Some of them are as follows; to achieve a 100% gross enrolment ratio in classes from pre school to secondary level by 2030 and 50% GER in higher education by 2035, to properly organize the efforts to help introduce nearly 2 crore children to the mainstream through the open schooling system and achieve an all inclusive and equitable education system by 2030 (Vajiram and Ravi, 2025). Some additional goals include setting up a new National Assessment Centre, PARAKH (Performance Assessment, Review, and Analysis of Knowledge for Holistic Development), achieving 100% youth and adult literacy and Setting up of National Research Foundation (NRF) (PIB, 2022). To put it in the words of policy makers themselves, NEP 2020 “envisions an education system rooted in Indian ethos that contributes directly to transforming India, that is Bharat, sustainably into an equitable and vibrant knowledge society, by providing high-quality education to all, and thereby making India a global knowledge superpower” (MHRD, 2020, p.6)

NEP and SDG 4: A Comparative Analysis

Both NEP and SDG 4, as it has been made clear by now, have a united purpose; to rid education and learning of hindrances like lack of resources, unavailability of infrastructure which includes well equipped classroom with e-resources and screens, properly chalked out syllabus for quality learning and even well trained and knowledgeable teachers. The ultimate aim of both NEP and SDG 4 is basically to make education accessible and affordable to every human being on the planet and so, a comparative analysis would reveal to what extent do they align with each other? It would also facilitate the understanding of how these two complement each other despite

major differences in the demographics, cultures and educational norms of the work areas they deal with. The official NEP document released by the government emphasizes the same. It says “This National Education Policy 2020 is the first education policy of the 21st century and aims to address the many growing developmental imperatives of our country. This Policy proposes the revision and revamping of all aspects of the education structure, including its regulation and governance, to create a new system that is aligned with the aspirational goals of 21st century education, including SDG4, while building upon India’s traditions and value systems” (MHRD, 2020, p.3)

Similarities and Points of Alignment

Since the declaration of SDG 4 precedes NEP 2020 and the United Nations urged each and every country to follow their well researched propositions to their own accord depending on the location and culture, it goes without saying that both NEP and SDG have many points of similarities amongst themselves. To begin with, universal right to education is a primary target for both of these initiatives. While target 4.1 of SDG 4 clearly says that primary and secondary education should be ensured to all the “girls and boys” alike, NEP corresponds to it mentioning that it is the initiative’s “top priority” to bring in the dropped out students back to the education fold and prevent further dropouts, resulting in a 100% GER by 2030 in all the class levels in schools (SDG resource document, 2020, p.4)(MHRD, 2020, p.10). Likewise, early childhood care and education (ECCE) has been described as a priority in both the policies. The target 4.2 of SDG 4 says how right from the pre-primary stage, children should have a strong basis to prepare themselves for primary education through holistic development and quality early education (p.4) and in agreement to this, the NEP narrates a full fledged plan comprising of different authorities and methods that would inculcate important facets like the importance of vernacular languages,

‘multilinguistic teaching’ and ‘foundational literacy’ from ages 2-8 (p.7-8, 13). On the issue of equality and inclusion, the very premise of both the documents in discussion is essentially the same; no discrimination and equal opportunities for all. Target 4.5 of SDG 4 indicates that immense focus should be laid on provision of quality training equally to men and women, eradicating gender discrimination and providing a better future to students belonging to indigenous groups and disabled communities (p.4). NEP 2020 is in agreement with this proposition and goes even beyond this when it includes transgenders and SEDGs (socio-economically disadvantaged groups) in the list of target groups that need more inclusion and representation. It even assigns a special gender inclusion fund along with many other schemes like Indian sign language teaching in it (p.24-28, 5, 15). The next area of alignment is related to inculcating skill development and employability in students. SDG 4, target 4.4 and 4.b say that there should be a substantial increase in the number of students with vocational skills which can help in making them more employable or be entrepreneurs without any barriers of sex, class or race (p.4). The efforts for this have to begin at an early developmental stage and so, unlike how the previous Indian education system focused more on disseminating theoretical knowledge and compartmentalize strict brackets of sciences, arts and commerce, it is NEP’s job to make sure that vocational training and entrepreneurial skills are initiated as a norm in early grades and that there is a certain level of freedom to choose from between vocational subjects and academic subjects. Aligning shoulder to shoulder with target 4.4, the Indian education system now includes developments like skill mapping, fun learning competitions, educational trips and excursions and vocational education right from the 6th grade. (p.5, 16). Another extremely important element of the entire process of learning is the teacher itself. Quality of teachers in schools is and has been a

very crucial aspect of learning but in India, this is the aspect that is troublesome in many cases¹.

SDG 4 in its target 4.c clearly narrates that all the countries in the world should work collaboratively to ensure that by 2030, there should be a ‘substantial increase’ and sustainable supply of good quality teachers in schools (p.4). India, through NEP, aims to achieve this target too and in the process, has made some changes in the existing state of affairs. B. Ed (Bachelor of Education), which is the qualifying degree for school teachers in India used to exist as a 2-year degree that could be undertaken separately. Now, NEP has mandated a 4 year integrated B. Ed to check teachers’ eligibility. Merit based scholarships shall also be provided to students in rural areas post completion of B. Ed to help them financially. The policy has also made sure that NTA (National Testing Agency) works rigorously to conduct continuous tests to filter out the incompetent teachers. This will inculcate professionalism and competence among teachers (p.20, 22-24, 43). One of the final but major points of alignment between SDG 4 and NEP 2020 is emphasis on lifelong learning and adult education. Target 4.6 of SDG 4 proclaims that countries need to make sure that by 2030, each and every person belonging to the youth and a substantial number of adults, both men and women, achieve literacy and numeracy (p.4). It is noteworthy that the common consensus defines literacy as the “ability to read, write, speak and listen in a way that lets us communicate effectively and make sense of the world” (NLT, 2025) and numeracy as the ability to use maths, not necessarily to solve complex questions like algebra or trigonometry but to get by everyday easily, to solve basic calculations without issues (NN, 2025). NEP is very serious about the issue of adult literacy. It proclaims adult literacy as a very priority subject and puts it on the same pedestal of importance as foundational literacy. It talks about the numerous disadvantages of illiteracy in day to day life and mentions that there is a

¹ See the last chapter ‘Challenges and Conclusion’

visible and observable link in high literacy and high per capita GDP in countries around the world. The plan of action to achieve 100% adult literacy under NEP would involve setting up a special adult literacy framework by NCERT, teaching vocational skills as a part of education to enhance employability, creation of a functioning machinery and suitable infrastructure to make sure that adult education reaches everyone who might want it. Some other key changes that would be introduced are providing easy availability of e-content, books and teachers along with local area AECs (Adult education centres) and so on (p.51-53). SDG 4 target 4.b (p.4) is also significant to look at because it urges the developing countries to substantially increase scholarships (possibly in amount and scope) to help the underprivileged access and thrive in various sectors of higher education. In resonance with this, NEP promises scholarships to students pursuing Indian arts and culture and many other disciplines in higher studies, to B. Ed graduates for helping their internship-stage, to the socio economically under privileged students and to meritorious students of various other accords. For ease of access, a web portal will be created for helping the students access and filter all the scholarships in one place (p. 28, 41, 56). Last but not the least, resonating with SDG 4 target 4.7 (p.4) which talks about the idea of peace, humanity and global citizenship, NEP 2020 discusses multiple times, the need of an education system that inculcates ethics and values in the students from an early age and teaches them to work side-by-side with their global colleagues in order to build a more peaceful world with global citizenship. It infuses the idea of peace and humanity as preached by SDG 4 with the indigenous ideas of *Shanti* (peace), *Satya* (Truth), *Dharma* (righteous conduct), *Prem* (love) and *Ahinsa* (non violence) (p.6, 15, 28, 37).

Most of the aims set up by NEP are ambitious and do correspond with SDG 4. Success of both these reforms await the implementation. That being said, something that is also very

important to understand is that despite multiple areas of alignment, NEP and SDG 4 are not identical and certainly have differences in some priorities and areas of interest. The paragraph below would highlight upon these differences.

Differences Between NEP and SDG 4: Taking Different Approaches.

Both NEP and SDG are attempts to fix the lacunae in the education system, making it a more inclusive and discursive space. Starting with the basics, a primary difference in NEP and SDG is the geographical scope. Where on one hand, NEP is designed to suit the needs and fix the issues of the Indian education system, SDG 4 provides a set of general targets for every country to modify or expand their education policies around. But here is a twist. Although NEP has been designed keeping SDG 4 in mind, it does not mean it will leave out its own element. For instance, since SDGs are a sequel to MDGs that operated from the year 2000 to 2015, SDGs have a defined period from 2015 to 2030 and then they will be succeeded by some other goals set. This can not be the case with NEP because unlike SDGs that are just guidelines, NEP is an in-action policy and it is tedious, expensive, not practical or even not fruitful to keep revising education policies every few years without seeing their impact over at least 3 to 4 generations. This is the reason why before NEP, the last major education policy of India came out in 1986 (Chaturvedi, 2020).

This, however, does not mean that NEP is haywire in its punctuality towards achieving goals. It has divided goals on the basis of their realistic achievement time. For example, stressing on quality ECCE (Early Childhood Care and Education) and foundational learning, NEP says that by 2030, every student entering grade 1 should be prepared for it. Likewise, the target year for achieving 100% GER from preschool to secondary level is also 2030. It also says that the professional standards for teachers will be revised in 2030 and thereafter, in every 10 years and

also that by 2030, the minimum requirement for becoming a teacher will be the newly launched 4-year integrated B. Ed, while the 2 year B. Ed will also be offered. Moreover, it is a part of the 2030 action plan that there should be at least 1 higher education institute near each district and that all the higher education institutes in the country should become multi-disciplinary. Additionally, all the stand-alone TEIs (Teachers' Education Institutes) will be required to be multi-disciplinary and have a 4-year integrated teachers' education framework (MHRD, 2020, p.7, 10, 23, 35, 42). Likewise, by the year 2035, NEP plans to increase the GER higher education from 26.3% in 2018 to 50% and through incentivization and external support, wants all higher education institutes to have an autonomous and empowered BoG (Board of Governors) (p.35, 49). As of the long term plans to be achieved by 2040, NEP wants India's education system to be "second to none" and advises the higher education institutes to definitely increase the enrolment of students in order to optimally use the resources (p.3, 35).

Another major difference (or rather addition) in NEP compared to SDG 4 is that while SDG 4 is outcome driven and philosophically based on the fundamental right of everyone to get education, NEP is not just limited to outcome. It repeatedly stresses on India 'reclaiming' its position in world education space as the *Vishwaguru* or the 'leader of the world'. The new education policy invokes ancient Indian genius minds like Aryabhata, Charakh, Chankaya etc and reminds the country of its glorious past of having had globally acclaimed universities and education centres like Takshila, Vallabhi and Nalanda in order to tell Indians that the new education policy is designed in a way to nurture the needs of a culture driven, value system based India which might walk shoulder to shoulder with the most advanced nations in terms of education standards and technology but will also be rooted in its roots (MHRD, 2020, p.3, 4). In yet another major difference, while target 4.a of SDG 4 briefly mentions 'building and

upgradation' of education facilities and infrastructure, the new Indian education policy has a well devised plan to revolutionarize the role of internet and ICT in Indian education system like never before. Whether it is everyday things like the use of AI tools to teach students, a compulsory demand from schools to build smart labs and screens or mammoth tasks like setting up NETF (National Education Technology Framework), NEP promises a digital future for Indian education. Institutions like NCERT, CBSE and NIOS will be made responsible for the creation and moderation of e-learning content and uploading it on the user-friendly platforms like DIKSHA, SWAYAM and SWAYAM PRABHA where they can be accessed, stored and shared for free. Similarly, for assessments and tests, platforms like PARAKH will be used and authorities like NTA (National Testing Agency)(p.19) will be responsible. However, the use of technology and AI will not be reckless and official distinction will be made to decide whether or not, the form of technology about to be used is progressive or detrimental to the cause of learning. There will also be an option to pursue PhD on multi-disciplinary subjects like "AI+x". In the coming age of Information Technology, the educational use of technology will soon be deployed to every sector including governance, administration and pedagogy and NEP serves as India's game plan to use this wave of technology for our benefit and be prepared for the challenges it poses and not just be amazed by it (p.56-60). Also, while SDG 4 just mentions that there should be equity and inclusivity among all school levels and higher education should be provided to everyone regardless of their sex, age and race, NEP 2020 lays down a complete roadmap as to how to improve and revolutionaries India's education system, involving setting up multiple schemes and policies to bring out the hidden potential that lies in the country and use it for the benefit of society (p.19, 24-26, 33-38).

There certainly exist multiple points of contact between SDG 4 and NEP 2020 as shown in the paragraph above but that does not mean the two are not compatible. In fact, as shown in the earlier sections of this research, NEP was formulated keeping in mind the educational goals and targets set by SDG 4. What the points of differences actually suggest is that although the main ideas like achieving 100% literacy and inclusion in education are the same, unlike SDG 4 that is a guideline issued to all the countries in the world, NEP is made specifically to meet the needs of the Indian population. This means that it has to be centred around Indian cultural, demographic and socio-political beliefs.

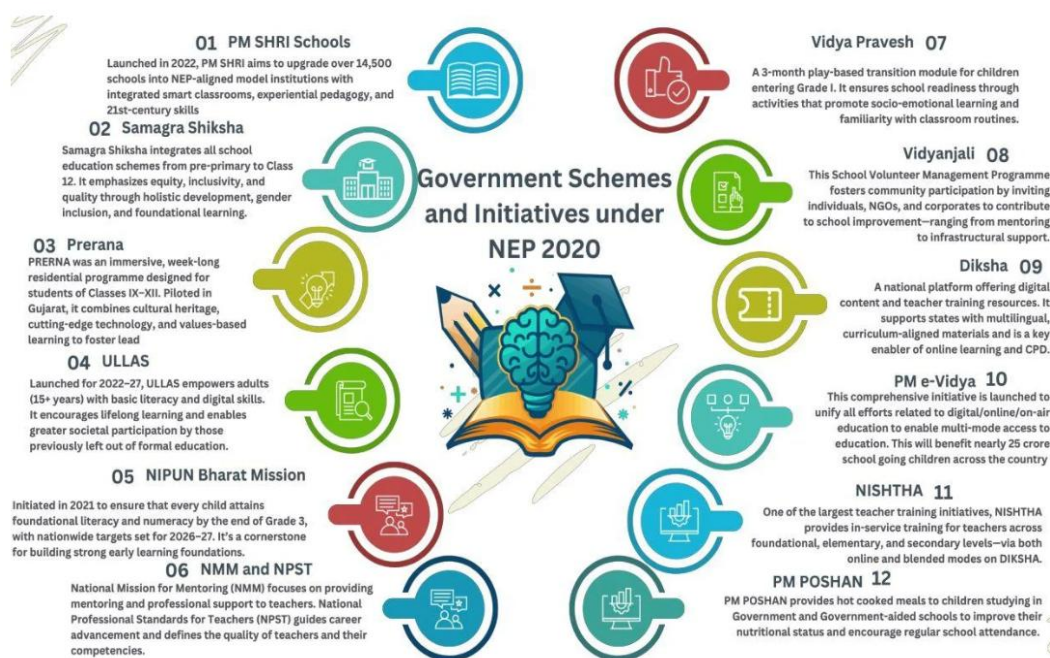
Chapter 3: Challenges and Conclusion

After a rigorous study of SDG 4 and NEP 2020, their origins and implementation, it can be said that the core motive behind both of them is fulfilling and well thought out. The areas that need improvement have been correctly marked and the implementation process is underway. Since SDG basically provides a set of guidelines, its success can only be measured when in 2030, UNO publishes its concluding report before initiating a new set of goals but with NEP, it's different. Released first in 2020, it is the fifth running year for the policy and only findings and data may tell us whether or not it has been successful and so, to understand how it has been thus far and how may the future of it be, it is significant to track these 5 years down.

As of August 2025, FLN (Foundational Literacy and Numeracy) through schemes like *NIPUN Bharat* and *Vidya Pravesh* has reached over 4.2 crore students and nearly 9 lakh schools all over the country. A little more than 1.15 lakh students belonging to the socio-economically backward groups have enrolled in schools and almost 8 lakh girls have also enrolled in residential schools (dristiias, 2025). This is a satisfying statistic because one major struggle of the Indian education system over the years has been to free the female children from the shackles

of patriarchy, which puts them to physical labour in fields and kitchens or marries them early to get rid of the responsibility to raise and feed them, and get them to enrol in schools and dream a successful and fulfilling life for themselves where they are allowed to do everything male students can.

As for the teachers' training, over 4 lakh teachers have been trained under NISHTA via DIKSHA and PM e-Vidya. 72% of schools now have internet access and with initiatives like Vidyanjali, DIKSHA, PM e-Vidya, e-Jaadui Pitara (AI-powered play-based learning) and AI Bots like *Katha Sakhi* and Teacher Tara, the dissemination of education has improved significantly (drishtiias, 2025). Given below is a depiction of some of the major beneficial and educational schemes launched by the government:



(drishtiias, 2025)

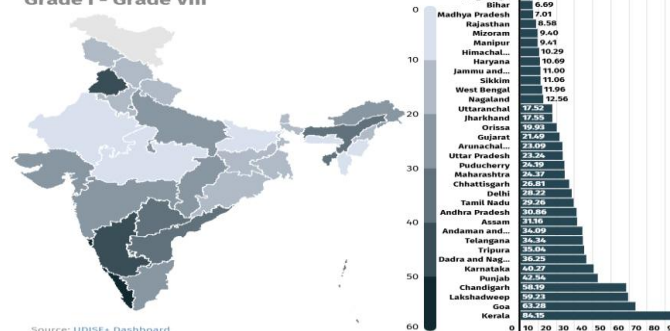
These achievements however, do not mean that the education system of the country is now free of all ailments but these can surely be seen as stepping stones and signs of much needed improvement; signs of hope that it can certainly get better. There are, however, some challenges

that are yet to be addressed structurally. The paragraph given below highlights some of those challenges.

One of the major challenges that persists in the education system of India is the quality of teaching, springing out of many factors like teaching environment and infrastructure and GER but most importantly, qualified teachers. Although it is not possible to exactly determine what percentage of teachers are 'bad' or incompetent or for that matter, what is a bad teacher after all because teaching is not a robotic activity with pre-known methods. What is a good teacher can be subjective but there can and should certainly be some defining norms on qualification standards other than entrance exams. According to a data report by Unified District Information System For Education Plus (UDISE+) for the year 2021-22, around 4,500 teachers of secondary and higher secondary levels in India have themselves not passed grade 10. Additionally, only 25% of teachers that joined in 2021-22 received some form of training (Iqbal, 2024). Some possible ways to improve this situation can be stricter supervision of the recruitment process, fair and transparent hiring and more stress on teaching skills than theoretical knowledge because bookish knowledge is rendered useless if the teachers lack the ability to disseminate it among the students. Favoured recruitments or the cases of bribery shall be taken seriously where the concerned authorities should punish the interior committee members involved by scraping their positions of power. Given below are two Indian map illustrations that show the proportion of elementary and high school teachers who have received in-job training and as visible, the situation in some states is critical.

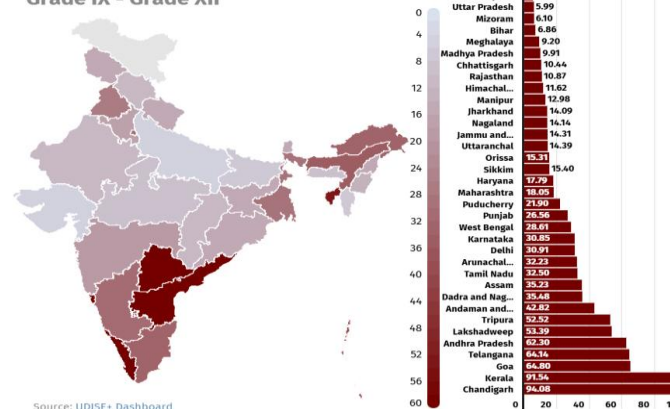
Proportion Of Elementary School Teachers Who Received In-Service Training

Grade I - Grade VIII



Proportion Of High School Teachers Who Received In-Service Training

Grade IX - Grade XII



(Iqbal, 2024)

Some other noteworthy constraints in the way of beneficial implementation of NEP are corruption in building and allocating of infrastructure and linguistic barriers among states. For example, states like Tamil Nadu and West Bengal are against the government when it comes to 3 language formula for students and conduction of common entrance tests (drishtias, 2025). These issues are, however, not particular to NEP and require attention anyway, although gradually but definitely. The dream of advancing to a digital India is not merely about generating and posting e-content on online platforms. It also means to know and spread the verified and quality content and differentiate technology with scam and spam. It also involves making it easy and affordable for everyone to access and use the internet and other technological infrastructure

to their own benefit. This challenge has very well been identified and marked for betterment by the NEP (MHRD, 2020, p.58).

It should be among the top priorities of the government to monitor the advancement of AI and technology closely and take corrective measures to ensure that there is no disruption or unfair practice in the entire process of digitalized education. As important as it is to keep up with the pace of educational technology around the world, it is also extremely important to protect the vested interests of teachers and students in the country. The situation caused by some of these constraints is harrowing and one may only hope that NEP is able to lift India out of its misery and ‘restores’ its title of *Vishwa Guru* as proclaimed in the document (MHRD, 2020, p.39). The bottomline here is that goals set by both NEP and SDG can not be successful on their own unless the concerned authorities do their part in implementation. At the end of the day, education is among the only sectors where negligence on the part of authorities involved does not just hamper the present generation but also deteriorates the quality standards and benchmark of learning for generations to come.

While the NEP 2020 has set ambitious goals for the Indian education system, achieving them remains a challenge. Progress has been made in foundational literacy, enrollment rates, and digital initiatives, but issues like poor teacher quality, corruption, and lack of digitizing still remain. In order to achieve a 100% gross enrollment ratio in school education by 2030 and 50% in higher education by 2035, there is a need for strong governance and more resources. There are also systemic barriers that need to be broken down as challenges in accessibility and affordability are still evident. Ultimately, the success of NEP will be determined by how effectively India can implement these policy visions across the entirety of its vast nation. The question of if NEP will really be able to meaningfully involve the sustainability goals, especially in education

throughout a developing nation like India remains. My view is that NEP can contribute to the sustainability agenda, but only if it is continuously adapting to the realities of a nation like India.

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